MEDIA RELEASE · REF. WSW-MR-2026/14 · ROCKINGHAM WA, 28 SEPTEMBER 2026 · FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE

Peron Point desalination plant to cut output for 23 days while divers replace worn brine diffuser nozzles

Warnbro Sound Water Company Pty Ltd · Lot 12 Point Peron Road, Rockingham WA 6168 · Media and Community Relations

From 2 to 24 November 2026 the Peron Point Seawater Desalination Plant will produce 70 to 105 megalitres a day instead of its usual 140, so that 36 of the 48 nozzles on its offshore brine diffuser can be replaced under the Peron Point Diffuser Renewal Project.

What is happening

Warnbro Sound Water Company Pty Ltd (WSWC), owner and operator of the Peron Point plant, today confirmed the dates and budget of the Peron Point Diffuser Renewal Project. The works will cost AUD 11.8 million, up from the AUD 9.4 million estimate given to the Rockingham community reference group in May 2026, mainly because a third diving vessel has been added to shorten the period of low output. Garnet Bay Diving Services of Mandurah will cut off each worn duckbill nozzle and clamp a new one onto the existing riser. The other 12 nozzles, replaced in 2022 after storm damage, stay in place.

"Customers will not notice any change at the tap. We have filled our storage ahead of the works," said WSWC Managing Director Bronwyn Tregenza.

Why now: the 2026 seabed survey

The plant's Marine Environmental Management Plan (MEMP) requires an independent survey of bottom water and seagrass around the outfall every winter. Shoalwater Benthic Consulting surveyed the outfall between 11 and 22 August 2026. Two sites close to the diffuser, PP-02 and PP-03, recorded dissolved oxygen below the MEMP trigger. Divers found many nozzles stiff and partly blocked by tubeworms, so the brine left them as slow, heavy jets that mixed poorly with seawater.

Table 1. Results of the 2026 bottom-water and seagrass survey, Peron Point brine outfall (Shoalwater Benthic Consulting, 11–22 August 2026)

Site	Distance from diffuser (m)	Salinity above background (PSU)	Bottom DO (% sat.)	Seagrass shoots per m²	MEMP status
PP-01	50	2.4	66	bare sand	Compliant
PP-02	150	1.9	57	bare sand	Exceedance
PP-03	300	1.4	58	bare sand	Exceedance
PP-04	400	1.3	63	412	Compliant
PP-05	600	1.1	71	688	Compliant
PP-06	1,500	0.3	86	1,040	Compliant
REF-N (Woodman Point)	7,800	0.0	93	1,160	Reference
REF-S (Shoalwater)	6,200	0.0	92	1,190	Reference

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How the MEMP triggers work

Under MEMP revision 6, in force since 1 July 2025, a site is in exceedance when its bottom-water dissolved oxygen (DO) is below 60 % saturation. A site outside the 400 m mixing zone is also in exceedance when its salinity is more than 1.2 PSU above background; sites at or inside 400 m are assessed on DO only. Until 30 June 2025 (revision 5) the DO trigger was 55 %.

One exceedance site requires a repeat survey within 30 days; two or more require corrective works to start within 120 days of the survey report, received on 9 September 2026.

Table 2. Plant output and marine exclusion zone during the diffuser works, November 2026

Phase	Dates (inclusive)	RO trains	Output (ML/day)	Nozzles replaced	Exclusion radius (m)
A – barge set-up	2–6 November	6	105	None (inspection)	150
B – outer section	7–14 November	4	70	Nos. 25–48 (24)	300
C – inner section	15–21 November	5	88	Nos. 1–12 (12)	300
D – dye tracer test	22–24 November	6	105	None	150

For boaters and divers

Four yellow buoys will mark an exclusion zone around the work barge, with the radius shown in Table 2. Fishing, diving and anchoring are not permitted inside it, and vessels must keep below 8 knots within 500 m of the barge. The Point Peron boat ramp stays open. Diving works run from 06:00 to 18:00 only.

Background: the plant

Commissioned in March 2011 at 100 ML a day and expanded to 140 ML a day in 2019, the plant supplies about 16 % of the drinking water in the metropolitan and Peel area. Brine is piped 1.1 km offshore to a 160 m diffuser at 14 m depth, whose upward jets dilute it about 45 times before it reaches the seabed.

Table 3. Peron Point plant at a glance (financial years ending 30 June)

Indicator	2024–25	2025–26
Drinking water produced (GL)	47.9	45.2
Recovery ratio (% of intake)	44.6	43.9
Specific energy (kWh per kL)	3.62	3.48
Power from contracted wind and solar (%)	71	78
RO membrane elements replaced (of 13,440)	1,104	1,376

After the works

Shoalwater Benthic Consulting will repeat the survey at sites PP-01 to PP-05 between 1 and 12 December 2026, and WSWC will publish a summary on its website by 31 January 2027. The removed nozzles will be shredded and recycled as rubber matting.

"Two low-oxygen readings is exactly the early signal the monitoring is designed to catch," said Environment Manager Declan Furlonger. Media visits to the work barge are possible on 10 and 17 November only, booked by 3 November.

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